As the great Mughals ruled and shaped north India, there arose and fell in the region centred around Hyderabad the Qutb Shahi dynasty (1512-1687). Patrons of the arts and learning, the nucleus of their power was the Golconda Fort, and scattered around it they constructed, through patient accretion, one of the most remarkable set of buildings in the entire medieval world. Spread over 100 acres, the successive line of rulers shaped a complex of 40 mausoleums, 23 mosques, five *baoli*s (stepwells) a *hammam* (bath), ornate pavilions and other garden structures. Once renowned for their sombre splendour, the garden necropolis had fallen upon hard times in recent decades—its lush vegetation stripped away by unbridled urbanisation, its magnificent structures robbed of granite blocks, the *baoli*s a repository of rubble, the domes blackened by neglect, intricate masonry in a dilapidated state. That was the situation when, in 2013, the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC) along with the Telangana government resolved to both restore the structures and revitalise the ecology of the landscape it is nestled in. They called it the Qutb Shahi Heritage Park. Thus started an intensive, decade-long conservation process involving hundreds of restorers and craftsmen that also sought to establish the area as a cultural space. Finally, Rahim Aga Khan, the second son of Karim Aga Khan, the head of the Nizari Ismaili Shia sect, formally handed over the



By the Golconda
An aerial view of the Qutb Shahi Heritage Park in Hyderabad with its monuments and gardens